Sylvia

By A.R. Gurney

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: Actor – Greg and Leslie Actress: Kate and Sylvia

Greg and Kate's apartment. Sylvia comes on, followed by Greg, holding a leash and a newspaper. She is pert and sexy. Her hair is messy and she wears rather scruffy clothes: a baggy sweater, patched jeans, knee pads, and old boots. A small nametag in the shape of a heart hangs around her neck. Greg wears business clothes, but his tie is loose. He watches Sylvia wander inquisitively around the room. She occasionally might take a sniff of something.

GREG: **(Pg 4-6)** What are you doing, Sylvia? Relax, why don't you?

SYLVIA: I gotta get used to things. *(She prowls)* I'm worried about where I sleep. Do I sleep on this couch?

GREG: *(He gives Sylvia a cuddle)* I want you to be on your best behavior. Kate gets home any minute.

SYLVIA: *(Sylvia gazes at him adoringly)* You saved my life. I never would have survived out there on my own. Someone else might have ignored me. Or shooed me away. Or even turned me in. Not you. You welcomed me with open arms. *(Sylvia hears something)* Hey!

GREG: What's the matter?

SYLVIA: *(Looking off)* Hey! Hey! Hey!

INTRODUCTION

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SYLVIA: **(Pg 6-7)** *(Looking off)* Hey! Hey! Hey!

GREG: What? *(He listens)* Oh, that. That's just Kate. Home from work.

SYLVIA: *(Unable to control herself)* Hey! Hey! Hey! Hey!

GREG: No, now quiet, Sylvia! Quiet down!

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KATE: Hello! *(Kate enters)* Am I crazy? I thought I heard a- *(Sees Sylvia)* Dog.

SYLVIA: *(Walking around Kate, looking her over)* Hi. I think I like you. Hi. *(Gives Kate a tentative kiss)*

KATE: *(Brushing her off)* Stop that. Go away! *(to Greg)* Greg, what is this?

GREG: I was sitting in the park, and Sylvia jumped right into my lap.

KATE: Back up, please. You were sitting? In the park? When were you sitting in the park?

GREG: This afternoon. I took a break from the office. *(Pause. Kate looks at Sylvia.)*

KATE: Sylvia? Why Sylvia?

GREG: The name was on her tag. *(Showing her)* See? "Sylvia." *(Sylvia begins to scratch)* It fits. I looked it up. It means "She of the woods." *(Sylvia is now scratching vigorously)*

KATE: She of the woods has fleas.

GREG: I'll deal with that. I'll get her all checked out.

KATE: **(Pg 8-9)** Sweetheart, I'm exercising a veto. No. N period. O period. Not in New York. Not at this stage of our lives. No. You work all day, I work all day. We go out a lot. There's no need.

GREG: ***I*** have a need. And she needs me. We've bonded, Kate.

KATE: Ooo. Ouch. That's an overworked word, Greg.

GREG: I really want her, Kate.

KATE: And I really don't. *(Looking at Sylvia)* What is she? A mutt?

GREG: I think she may be part poodle.

SYLVIA: *(Assuming a saucy position)* Mais oui, Monsieur. Ooo la la.

KATE: Is she house-trained?

SYLVIA: *(Uneasily)* Oh yes. Definitely. Absolutely. No question.

GREG: She was a good girl walking home, weren't you, Sylvia? *(talking baby talk)* We were a very good girl. 'Twice. Weren't we?

KATE: I may puke, Greg.

SYLVIA: **(Pg 10-11)** I think you're prejudiced against dogs! *(She leaps onto the couch, circles and lays down)*

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KATE: Off, Sylvia!

SYLVIA: You speaking to me?

KATE: I said off that couch! Right now! *(Pulls Sylvia off the couch)* And stay off.

SYLVIA: Easy! Take it easy! . . . Jesus!

KATE: This is not going to work. **(Pg 12)** We'll give you to The Animal Rescue League. Or the Humane Society.

SYLVIA: They suck! Have you ever been there? The rows of cages. They have time limits. If someone doesn't bail you out, within five days, they put you to sleep. They kill you! Listen. It's a tough world out there, lady. I know. I've been there. *(Leaps into Greg's arms.)*

GREG: **(Pg 13-15)** Let me at least try her, Kate. A few days, at least.

KATE: *(exasperated)* All right. For a few days we will try Sylvia.

SYLVIA: Yippee! Yay!

KATE: I want one thing dear, Greg. She's yours, not mine. I won't feed her, and I won't walk her, and I don't want her jumping onto any of the- *(Sees something on the floor)* What's that? *(Disgusted)* She's pee'd, Greg. *(Sylvia is embarrassed)*

GREG: She was nervous, Kate. Strange place. Hostile atmosphere. . .

SYLVIA: 'That's it. That was the problem. *(Hugging him)* I love this man. I adore him.

KATE: Rub her nose in it at least! She's got to learn!

SYLVIA: Hey! Hey! Hey!

GREG: *(Putting Sylvia's leash back on)* Tell you what -- We'll go out.

SYLVIA: Did I hear the word "out"? Knew it! Can't wait! Love going out! *(Dragging him toward the front hall.)* Come on, Greg!

******** Scene ********

GREG: **(Pg 18-20)** *(Off-stage)* We're home! I've got a surprise for you. Ta da. *(Proudly he presents Sylvia)* I had her professionally groomed. *(Sylvia comes on with a new hairdo, a bow in her hair, and a corny outfit.)*

SYLVIA: Look at me! Look at me! *(Shimmying)* How do you like them apples?

GREG: They gave her the full treatment: flea dip, nails clipped, ears cleaned, the works. They

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told me she was crawling with fleas. You were right about that, Katie. But now look at her. Isn't she spectacular? *(Sylvia dances around joyously)* Don't you want to keep her now? *(Bringing Sylvia to Kate)*

SYLVIA: *(Holding out her hand to be kissed)* Enchant!, Madame.

KATE: Greg, please. *(She exits)*

SYLVIA: She doesn't like me.

******** Scene ********

KATE: **(Pg 27)***(to audience)* She waits, you know. She literally waits, until I'm out the door, and then she leaps onto that couch. She only listens to Greg. They do everything together. Once I caught them sharing an ice cream cone and . . . **(Pg 29)** She drinks from the toilet! And lately he's been taking the afternoon off. Every day! He and Sylvia have lunch and go on these long walks. She's destroying our marriage.

GREG: **(Pg 30)** *(Off-stage)* Hello!

SYLVIA: **(Pg 35-36)** *(Hears Greg and excitedly enters carrying a woman's shoe)* Look what I've got! *(Parading it around)* Look at this fabulous shoe!

KATE: Drop that, Sylvia! Right now! *(she attempts to get the shoe)*

GREG: She just wants to play.

SYLVIA: Chase me. Hey! Hey! Hey!

KATE: Time's up. I said I'd try, and I have. I'm putting my foot down, Greg. I am issuing an ultimatum. Give Sylvia away.

GREG: *(Ignoring the statement)* It's time for her dinner. *(To Sylvia)* Come on, sweetheart. Time to eat. *(As they exit Sylvia makes a rude gesture of some type)*

KATE: *(Calling after)* Sweetheart? Is it sweetheart now? Dammit, Greg! When's the last time you said that to me?

********Scene********

LESLIE: **(Pg 48)** I must say, Kate, I find it somewhat difficult to counsel married couples when one of the partners refuses to cooperate. I thought your husband agreed to join us.

KATE: Let's simply assume he's with Sylvia . . .

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LESLIE: *(Consulting notes)* During our last session, you seemed to suggest that he had actually fallen in love with Sylvia.

KATE: He has! Totally! Even when we were first married, he never looked at me the way he looks at Sylvia. *(Greg comes in, breathlessly)*

LESLIE: **(Pg 49-50)** Kate, why don't you go in the other room and read a magazine. I'd like to talk to Greg alone. *(Kate goes out)*

LESLIE: Sit down, Greg. Talk to me . . . Say whatever is on your mind.

GREG: O.K. *(Pause)* She's not herself lately. Particularly these past few weeks. She resents me.

LESLIE: And why do you suppose she resents you?

GREG: Because I made the decision (pause, he speaks quietly, ashamed) to have her spayed.

LESLIE: Ah . . . You're talking about . . .

TOGETHER: Sylvia.

GREG: She's got great eyes. Deep, serious eyes. But that doesn't mean she's serious all the time. She laughs. I've actually seen her laugh. And she's got this great little butt. When she sashays down the street, she kind of wiggles it back and forth.

LESLIE: **(Pg 52)** Greg. I think it's time to move on. May I bring in Kate so we can all sit down together.

GREG: Aren't you forgetting Sylvia? You've seen Kate, you've seen me, don't you think you should see Sylvia?

LESLIE: You want me to hold a session with your dog?

********Scene********

GREG: **(Pg 54-55)** *(Pause)* Sylvia, I have to send you away. It boils down to you or Kate, Sylvia. And I'm choosing Kate. I've found a family for you.

SYLVIA: You're choosing Kate? Is this because she hates me?

GREG: She doesn't hate you, Sylvia. She doesn't like me, Sylvia. When I'm with you.

SYLVIA: I thought there was talk of you and me moving out. Getting a studio apartment right near the park. *(Greg shakes his head sadly) (Sylvia, aloof)* Tell me about this family you're shipping me off to.

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GREG: *(with excitement)* They're great, Sylvia. I interviewed a number of applicants. **(Pg 56-57)** They have children. They want to teach you to play Frisbee. They want to take you to Little League games. They'll be much better for you than I could possibly be.

SYLVIA: I hate *children.* They're totally unreliable. They forget to feed you. They play music which hurts your ears. One minute they're showering you with love, then they leave you locked in some car for hours on end- *(Throwing herself on him)* Oh Greg, don't do this to me! Please! I'll change my ways. I'll stop chewing shoes. I'll bring Kate the New York Times every morning! Just tell me what to do, and I'll do it! Please!

GREG: I promised Kate I'd give you away, Sylvia. I made that promise. To my wife.

SYLVIA: Jesus, you're something, Greg. You really are. You bring me home, you get me all dependent on you, you spay me ... You had me spayed, Greg! Christ, Greg! Don't you feel guilty?

KATE: *(From off)* Hello! *(Sylvia turns away haughtily; Kate sees that Greg is upset)* **(Pg 58)** I know this is hard for you.

GREG: I can't talk about it, Kate. It's too painful at the moment. *(He exits)*

KATE: **(Pg 59-60)** *(to Sylvia)* I wish it could have been otherwise, Sylvia.

SYLVIA: *(Long beat – Mimics Kate)* "I wish it could have been otherwise." Know what "otherwise" is, Kate? Otherwise is those sad couples sitting in restaurants night after night, eyeing each other, with absolutely nothing to say. That's otherwise, Kate. *(pause)* "This wise" is the fact that he can never be happy with me unless you like me, too. Which is why he is always foisting me on you. [It's] called sharing, Kate. Which is what some people sometimes call love. Of course, what do I know? I'm only a dog. *(She exits to find Greg)*

KATE: *(Thinks for a moment)* Oh hell. *(She goes off determinedly after Greg and Sylvia)*

********Scene********

(all lines are spoken to the audience)

GREG: **(Pg 60-61)** We never got to the suburbs. I called and said we'd changed our minds.

KATE: I changed my mind.

GREG: Once I came home and found Kate and Sylvia side by side on the couch. Kate was

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reading The Hidden Life of Dogs, and Sylvia had her head in Kate's lap.

KATE: This is an absolute lie!

GREG: And Sylvia stayed with us for the next eleven years, until we had to put her down. I held her when the vet gave her the shot. She looked at me, gave a little sigh, lay down quietly, and died. *(Pause)* Kate was waiting for me when I got home, and we both cried.

KATE: That's not true. I did not cry.

GREG: Whatever. Oh, Sylvia's looks changed. I'll show you. *(He takes a small photograph out of his wallet)* There. That's Sylvia.

KATE: I took that picture the year before she died. *(they look at the picture)* I'm afraid she looks a little the worse for wear.

GREG: She does not, Kate! She still looks absolutely gorgeous!

(The lights fade on Greg and Kate, very much together, looking at Sylvia's picture.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

For inspiration, watch a short clip from the Broadway production with Sarah Jessica Parker as Sylvia
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=S0oE0a6exk8

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